Writing Assignment 1

Geography 5312

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This writing assignment examines the question: What specifically can urban designers do to react and respond to this trend offering spaces that are more engaging for personal interaction? Citizens and city officials have been pushing to revitalize downtowns in cities throughout the nation, but some such as Mike Davis in his book "City of Quartz", are concerned that this push will somehow move suburbia back into the downtown area and sabotaging the initial goal of reforming the downtown into a viable place for people to engage in personal interaction. One of the downsides of the reform movement in many city downtowns is the loss of public space by poor planning and allowing developers to work in isolation outside of a comprehensive plan. The question posed here is this: How can a city ensure that space open for personal interaction be created by revitalizing the downtown? First of all, the downtown needs to be an attractive destination for people in order to have engaging spaces for personal interaction. In order to attract people to the core of a city, you want a downtown that combines the advantages of being centrally located with some of the advantages that suburbs and exurbs enjoy. In simple terms, in order to have an engaging interaction of people, you need get the downtown to be a comfortable place to live, work, play and shop. If these four aspects are met, then more people will be able to enjoy the central city and all it has to offer. It's important that these criteria are met in an integrated way that combines all four as opposed to having isolated or guarded pods such as an enclosed mall setting. For this to happen, the downtown needs to be accessible for those who don't live or work there. Second, the downtown needs to have a high percentage of residences. Third, the downtown needs to have designated common areas easily accessible and comfortable for the visitors and residents. Fourth, the downtown needs to host events, fairs, farmer's markets to bring people together.

Having desirable areas around downtown are nice, but a without a transportation system integrating these, the downtown flow of traffic can become either stagnant or it can put pedestrians and bicyclists in harm's way.

Improving the accessibility to downtown with mass transportation to and from the core and possibly within the core will help with bring more people into the downtown area without clogging the streets with automobiles.

Various ways getting to downtown need to be explored including improving mass transportation getting to downtown and making better bus stops with covered bus stops. If there is a rail system planned in the city, include various key stops in the downtown area and to have the train stations strategically located in around the city that include wide range of people and with adequate parking. To create a more eco-friendly way of getting to downtown is integrating a dedicated pedestrian and/or bicycle routes with the existing street or converting some streets to be entirely free of automobiles. One example of this is in Austin where Riverside Drive intersects Lamar Blvd. The high pedestrian traffic in the area prompted the city to build a dedicated pedestrian bridge adjacent to the Lamar bridge and Riverside itself and went from four lanes to two lanes with a wider pedestrian walkway next to the street. Another example that is proposed is to convert Nueces Street in downtown to be free of automobiles in an effort to create a viable north/south bicycle and pedestrian route.

Also, within the downtown area a mass transportation system that transports the visitors in and around the major points of interest will help the mobility for them. The cable car in San Francisco is an example of this kind of transportation. Austin used to have “The Dillo” that was free of charge that were buses with a cable-car façade. Unfortunately, budget cuts eliminated this about five years ago.

Visitors to downtown using the automobile will need improved parking to serve the entire downtown. Parking does not have to be for one particular area. Central parking for multiple facilities provides a way for people to park and stay in the downtown area as they do a variety of activities. This will nudge the visitors to areas that may not be their original destination.

By increasing the green areas situated between popular spots, visitors can find a place for solitude or to socialize. Republic Park in Austin is a public example of a green area like this. Incentives can be made for a minimum amount of green space per set area that is not exclusive for any particular entity. Families can benefit from open spaces as much or more than others. By making open areas more family friendly, more families can feel good about moving to or visiting downtown. To do this, open areas can have play areas, small shops or kiosks in and around the open spaces can sell snack foods and refreshments. Austin's downtown revitalization started with 6th Street back in the 1980's and still it caters towards you single and childless couples with the addition of bars and expensive restaurants. As a result, the downtown still does not have a family friendly atmosphere. This will infuse a daytime group in the downtown area besides downtown workers.

To gain a higher percentage of residents to downtown, multiuse developments combining retail, commercial, and residential is one way to bring a large number of people to a small area. This is a nice alternative to common high rise condominiums that can have a secluded and exclusive feel to a visitor. The Domain in Austin is an example of a multiuse development. It's an attempt to revitalize a brown field IBM plant into a multiuse facility. It has retail with residences and businesses above surrounded by a picturesque layout of green areas and low street lighting to create an intimate feel. As for high-rise condominiums and other tall buildings, the ground floors need to be pedestrian friendly with retail and adequate sidewalks. It's also important to note that downtown residents should be able to stay within the downtown area for most of their basic needs such having an adequate grocery store and medical care. By having a large percentage of residents downtown, the downtown will always have a larger number of people with a vested interest in all what's going on and to keep the quality of life as high as it can.

Once the infrastructure is in place, you need create a variety of way to bring people there. Annual festivals, fairs, music festivals and farmers markets are only a few ways to do this. With the infrastructure in place, the events can be easily accessible and visitors can have an abundant space to enjoy the outdoors. In Austin, the Austin Music Festival, Austin City Limits Festival, South by Southwest, Pecan Street Festival along with farmers markets at

Republic Square, give the downtown a constant influx of people from in town to out of town. Another way to bring people in is for the managers of the residences downtown to host “open house” days to bring people in to show visitors the amenities of living downtown.

In conclusion, by creating an environment where people can live, work, play and shop in the best environment possible and giving them easy ways to get there and abundant reasons to visit, you create spaces that are engaging for personal interaction. Not only are you creating the space for it, but you are making the surrounding area conducive to bring it there.